



The Order Trace

Interview thesis brief | Director, MedTech Digital Factory - OTC

A Digital Factory should convert recurring friction into governed process products - making every order explainable, every exception visible, and every improvement reusable.

MANDATE HYPOTHESIS

Turn fragmented, exception-heavy MedTech OTC work into a governed portfolio of digital process products that improves customer service, operating visibility, control, adoption, and economic performance without destabilizing continuity.

Operating assumption: OTC is treated as Order-to-Cash and should be validated during discovery against J&J's internal mandate and process boundaries.

COMPANY MOMENT

Accelerated growth

Q1 2026 J&J sales were \$24.062B, up 9.9% reported. MedTech sales were \$8.636B, up 7.7% reported and 4.6% operational.

Portfolio movement

MedTech growth across electrophysiology, Abiomed, Shockwave, and trauma; an Enterprise Business Review planned; and intended separation of Orthopaedics.

CENTRAL TENSIONS

Global standard vs legitimate complexity

Standardize customer and control-critical decisions without erasing necessary market, product, and relationship judgment.

Transformation pace vs continuity

Change the system while protecting current commitments, controls, and operating stability.

Automation vs accountability

Move stable rules faster while preserving visible human authority for consequential exceptions.

Platform output vs value realization

Judge digital products by retained use, lower recurrence, customer impact, and economics - not release volume.



How the operating model works

Commitment > Validation > Availability > Fulfillment > Delivery > Invoice > Payment > Learning

FRICION COMPRESSION SYSTEM

Question	Decision	Output
Where does recurrence originate?	Trace to data, process, policy, handoff, integration, or authority.	Root-friction statement.
Is the variation legitimate?	Separate required complexity from avoidable burden.	Exception taxonomy.
What intervention fits?	Eliminate, standardize, redesign, assist, automate, or escalate.	Bounded process product.
What authority remains human?	Name decision owner and escalation boundary.	Authority contract.
What proves value?	Measure customer, flow, control, economics, adoption, and learning.	Evidence standard.
Can it scale?	Confirm data, rules, ownership, conditions, and retained value transfer.	Scale, partner, hold, redesign, or stop decision.

DECISION ARCHITECTURE

Portfolio entry

Which friction is recurring, material, owned, measurable, and worth intervention?

Intervention class

What changes in the workflow, and what should remain human?

Funding and stop

What evidence earns further investment, reuse, redesign, or retirement?

BALANCED SCORECARD

Customer	Commitment reliability; disruption; resolution experience.
Flow	Cycle time; first-pass quality; handoff latency; aged exceptions.
Economics	Cost-to-serve; avoidable rework; working capital; expedite burden.
Control and trust	Traceability; evidence completeness; policy consistency; auditability.
Adoption	Retained use; proficiency; workaround reduction; workflow ownership.
Learning	Exception recurrence; iteration speed; reuse with retained value.



Why the evidence transfers

PROOF MAP

Vape-Jet - current operating transformation

Cross-functional transformation across production, purchasing, quality, customer success, support, engineering issue flow, ERP/Odoo, CRM, collaboration systems, telemetry, and AI-assisted work.

Amazon - customer-backward scale and cadence

Prime operation supporting approximately five million second-day orders annually; labor, throughput, escalation, standard work, safety, quality, and customer experience.

Compunetics - high-reliability technical execution

Engineering, manufacturing, quality, customer delivery, root cause, process control, evidence, and high-consequence stakeholder collaboration.

DudeWorth - AI opportunity and governance design

Value, feasibility, data readiness, governance, adoption burden, reuse, time-to-value, human judgment, escalation, evaluation, and agentic workflow patterns.

STRONGEST OBJECTION

Concern: Russell has not already led a global MedTech OTC or major SAP transformation.

Response: Do not disguise the gap. Position the transfer: he has led inside the customer, operational, technical, quality, logistics, ERP, and adoption systems enterprise technology must improve. He would partner with J&J's process, platform, architecture, data, and compliance experts while bringing operator discipline to workflow truth, ownership, standard work, escalation, adoption, and measurable outcomes.

CHANGE BURDEN

The model requires leaders and workflow owners to baseline work, expose exceptions, clarify decision rights, practice new behaviors, own outcomes, and return evidence. The Digital Factory must make those requirements lighter and more useful than the burden it removes.

INTERVIEW POSTURE

Use tactical empathy before prescription. Treat the model as a hypothesis to test. Ask where the current system already works, where local complexity is legitimate, and what prior transformation attempts taught the organization.



Entry plan and executive questions

Days 1-30	Days 31-60	Days 61-90	Days 91-120
OTC Reality Map: journeys, exception customer impact.	Exception Portfolio: taxonomy, owners priority.	Proof and Adoption Review: bounded stop decisions.	Scaling Contract: process-product ownership, reuse cadence, next investments.

EXECUTIVE QUESTIONS

1. Which OTC exceptions create the greatest customer or patient-care consequence, and which create the greatest internal burden?
2. Where does J&J need global consistency, and where must local market or product judgment remain intentionally different?
3. How are Digital Factory products currently owned after launch?
4. What evidence causes J&J to scale, redesign, partner, or stop an intervention?
5. Where is transformation fatigue strongest, and what has earned trust?
6. How does the intended Orthopaedics separation change dependencies or continuity burden?

AUTHORITATIVE SOURCES

Original J&J careers posting R-087466; J&J Q1 2026 results; J&J Orthopaedics separation announcement; J&J MedTech official site.

Closing thesis: The work is not to digitize every handoff. It is to make the customer commitment traceable, compress avoidable recurrence, preserve accountable judgment, and compound what proves useful.